Tales of Defiance to Mind Control in the Modern Age
Syllabus

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Title: Tales of Defiance to Mind Control in the Modern Age
Title Abbreviation: DMC
Study Group Leader: Scott Axelrod

Meeting Times/Dates: Mondays, Period 2 (11:10 am – 12:35 pm), November 2-30
Location: 51 Sawyer Road, second floor.
Contact: axelrod@alumni.princeton.edu
Course Number: HG19-LIT-5b-Mon2-F26
Preparation Time: 2–3 hours per week, which includes time to watch the movies and read some additional materials.

Course Description in BOLLI Course Catalog

Are you concerned about the increasingly sophisticated ways social forces are attempting to control your mind? In this course we examine four different mind control scenarios as depicted in four seminal works of fiction. In each case, the lead character seeks to defiantly challenge a specific threat to mental autonomy. Taken together, these works of fiction (three films and a short story) trace an arc of defiance against increasingly sophisticated and multi-layered methods of thought control.

We begin with a filmed one-man play version of Fyodor Dostoevsky's *Notes from the Underground* – a visceral scream against a world that imposes rationalism as the highest ideal. Next, in a film adaptation of George Orwell's *1984*, "Big Brother" uses totalitarianism and a vocabulary of submission to colonize the inner self. From there we enter the digital age with *The Matrix* (the Wachowskis' 1999 film), exploring an engineered reality that replaces the physical world entirely. Finally, Ken Liu's short story "The Perfect Match" (2012) confronts invisible control through the "corporate nudge" of algorithms and big data.

Applying literary analysis, philosophy, and social theory, we examine how power and psychology shape what we call "real." In discussing these narratives, we aim to build the intellectual muscles that each of us needs to navigate a world fractured by algorithms, social media, and the onslaught of AI, all the while resisting the persistent pull of old-fashioned ideological brainwashing.

Course Topics by Week

Week 1, Nov. 2: Introduction, *Notes from the Underground*

Course Overview:

- In each of the first four weeks, we will focus on a tale of societally imposed mind control and (at least one) tool, or lens, to examine the story.
- Together, these works form an increasingly sophisticated, multi-layered arc of stories and lenses.
- Even while new forms of control emerge, the old ones are still present today.
  People are still rebelling …
  1. against The Enlightenment, as the Underground Man did in *Notes from the Underground*;
  2. against state control of truth, as Winston Smith did in *1984*;
  3. against a virtual fake reality, as Neo did in *The Matrix*; and
  4. against companies controlling us by telling us what we want, as Sai did in "The Perfect Match."
- The lenses used to look at each story are actually questions that apply to all stories:
  1. Human Outlier Perspective: How are people outside of the "normal" for society treated?
  2. Narrative Perspective: How are stories told, and how does that affect people?
     Police State Perspective: To what extent does the government control civil society?
  3. Societal Control Perspective: What are the mechanisms by which society exerts control to constrain its members?
  4. False Needs Perspective: How are people manipulated into acting based on a sense of what they need?
     Surveillance Capitalism Perspective: How does constant surveillance affect people in society?

Notes from the Underground

- Feelings/complexity are suppressed by the dominance of simple rationalism.
- Early Enlightenment models of deeply surveilled prisons and mental hospitals are used to isolate and outcast people with "crazy" thoughts.
- Those who control what thoughts are "acceptable" control the perceived reality.

Week 2, Nov. 9: *1984*

- Connection to *Notes from the Underground*, *We*, *Brave New World*.
- *1984*:
  - Independent thoughts and feelings are disallowed under totalitarianism.
  - This is enforced by surveillance and control of language and media.
  - Those who control the narrative control the perceived reality.

Week 3, Nov. 16: *The Matrix*

- People are living inside a computer simulation.
- They cannot perceive that their reality is constructed and controlled by the architects of the digital world.
- Those who control the information people receive control the perceived reality.

Week 4, Nov. 23: "The Perfect Match"

- Independent thoughts and feelings are not possible because algorithms and bots steer how people think and feel.
- People are lured by the comfort of a constructed, false-but-pleasant narrative.
- Those who provides the most comfort controls perceived reality.

Week 5, Nov. 30: Final Wrap-up

- Pulling it all together and looking forward.

Course Materials

The core of the course consists of four works, which can be accessed by the links below.

Note: When this file is viewed as a web page, each link below opens in a new browser tab.

Additional/optional materials will be provided on the class website and in email.

"Notes from the Underground," one-man show starring Larry Cedar, 1h32m, free on YouTube



"1984" movie directed by Michael Radford, 1h51m, free on Tubi TV



***The Matrix* movie, written and directed by the Wachowskis, 2h16m**

- $3.99 to rent on YouTube. Need to create a free YouTube login.
- $3.99 to rent, $14.99 to buy on Amazon Prime Video. Need an Amazon Prime account.



"The Perfect Match," free on Lightspeed Magazine



SGL Biography

In his career as a mathematical physicist, Scott Axelrod studied geometrical quantum field theories as an assistant professor of mathematics at MIT before working on nuclear magnetic resonance, natural language processing, and finance in industry. On the humanistic side, Scott has self-published the books "Off the Deep End: Diary of a Mathematician", "Infinite Regress", and "After-Time". Much of the latter book consists of essays for the BOLLI Writers Guild. He has several other works in progress. Scott is looking forward to his first teaching experience at BOLLI.